

RESEARCH REPORT . AUGUST 2026

The *UK Podcast* Landscape

2026 Edition

A research-grade study of **6,693 active British podcasts** with an established UK audience. All reach and audience figures here are modelled estimates built from this dataset, not direct measurements. The picture: a market of extraordinary breadth and extreme concentration, where the top 1% of shows command about a fifth of all listening, the vast majority publish without a network, and a small tier of professional studios is quietly consolidating the top.

6,693

ACTIVE UK PODCASTS

*With an established UK audience***~21%**

LISTENING HELD BY THE TOP 1%

*A very short head***~90%**

INDEPENDENT

*Roughly one in ten carry a network***~24%**

CARRY SPONSORSHIP

A deep, unsold mid-tier

CONTENTS

In this report

Executive Summary <i>Six findings that define the UK market</i>	p. 3
Key Findings <i>The six structural findings, in depth</i>	p. 4
Market Structure <i>A long tail and a very short head</i>	p. 7
Maturity & Vintage <i>A market that has aged into its audience</i>	p. 8
Independent vs Network <i>A market of independents, led by its broadcasters</i>	p. 9
Monetisation & Sponsorship <i>Where the money is, and where it isn't</i>	p. 11
Engagement & Discoverability <i>Ratings don't separate the field, reviews do</i>	p. 15
Platform & Distribution <i>Spotify is universal, video is the frontier</i>	p. 17
Content & Format <i>The triple stack the leaders share</i>	p. 19
Where Hosts Are Based <i>London at the centre</i>	p. 21
Behind & In Front of the Mic <i>The audience is not the creators</i>	p. 22
Top 10 by Apple-anchored reach <i>The shows that anchor the ecosystem</i>	p. 24
Key Insights <i>Ten things to take away</i>	p. 26
The Leader's Checklist <i>Score your show against the top-10 playbook</i>	p. 27
Strategic Implications <i>What this means for the industry</i>	p. 28
Conclusion <i>An independent market consolidating</i>	p. 29
Methodology <i>How this report was built</i>	p. 30

ABOUT THIS EDITION

This PDF edition reproduces the interactive report published at millionpodcasts.com/research/the-uk-podcast-landscape-2026. The concentration simulator and the self-assessment scorecard appear here as static figures; the live versions remain interactive on the web.

— 01 . EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

What the data is saying about British podcasting in 2026.

Six findings that define the state of the UK market, each drawn directly from the data, each consequential for the creators, advertisers and networks competing within it.

~21% A market with a very short head The top 1% of UK shows account for about a fifth of estimated listening; the top 10% account for around six in ten. Attention is far more concentrated than the catalogue's size suggests.	~90% An independent-built ecosystem About 645 shows, roughly one in ten, carry a recognised network or publisher affiliation, led by the BBC. The catalogue is still overwhelmingly the work of independent creators, but its biggest publishers are broadcasters, not podcast studios.
~24% Monetisation is still the exception Only about one in four UK shows runs sponsorship. For advertisers, that still signals a deep pool of engaged, as-yet-uncommercialised inventory.	~2.7x The network premium is large Networked shows post a median audience roughly 2.7 times that of independents, an association rather than a proven effect, and the tier is led by the ad-free BBC.
~18% The unclaimed video frontier About 18% of UK shows carry a linked YouTube channel, a conservative floor, since video without a linked feed is not counted, yet those that do post audiences around 58% larger. Video is the clearest untapped lever.	London One city, disproportionate gravity Among shows with at least one UK-based host, over two-fifths (~42%) have a London-based host, more than ten times the next city, Manchester.

A GENUINELY LIVE CATALOGUE

About 78% of the shows in this report published a new episode within the last 90 days, and 59% within the last 30. This is the live UK podcast market in 2026, not a long tail padded with dormant feeds.

02 . KEY FINDINGS

Six structural findings that define UK podcasting today.

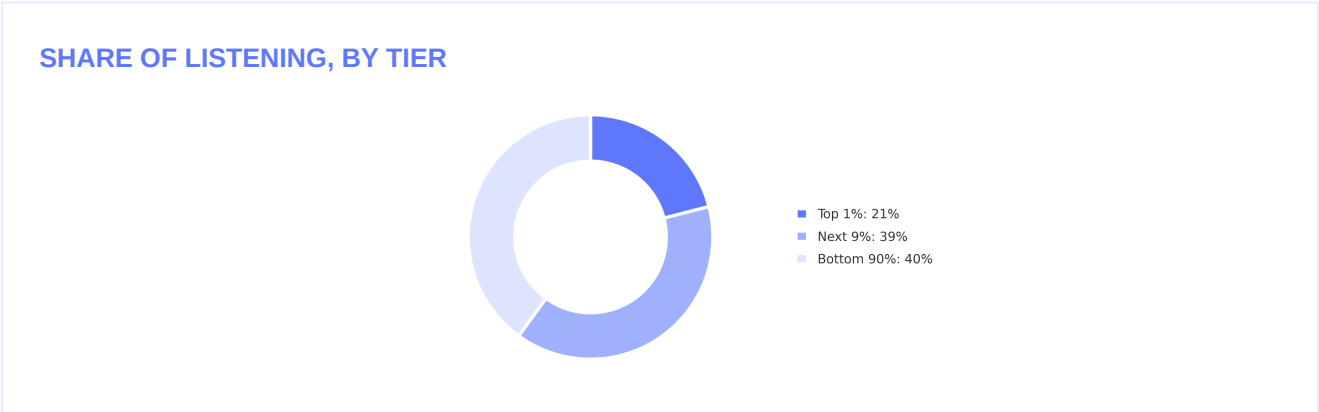
Each pairs a strategic pattern with the chart that evidences it. In the interactive edition these are selectable panels; here they run in sequence.

FINDING 01 AUDIENCE CONCENTRATION

Audience is concentrated at the top.

A steep power curve, not a level field.

The leading 1% of shows hold about a fifth of all listening; the top 10% hold around 60%. Reach, not content volume, is the scarce resource in this market.

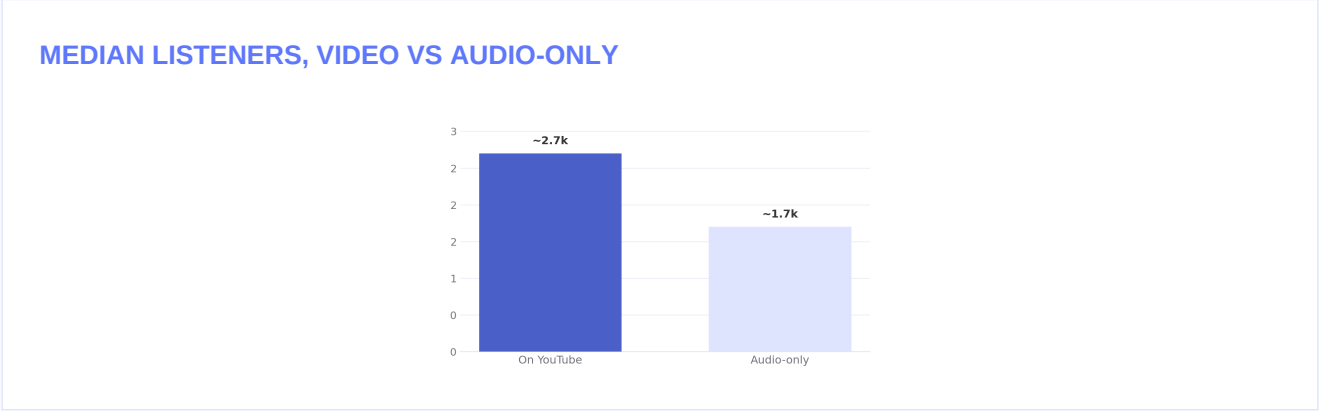


FINDING 02 THE VIDEO GAP

Video is the open lever.

Few shows are on YouTube; those that are run larger.

Only ~18% of UK shows maintain a YouTube channel, yet their median audience is materially larger than audio-only peers. Video is the clearest distribution gap in the market, and the one most strongly associated with larger audiences.

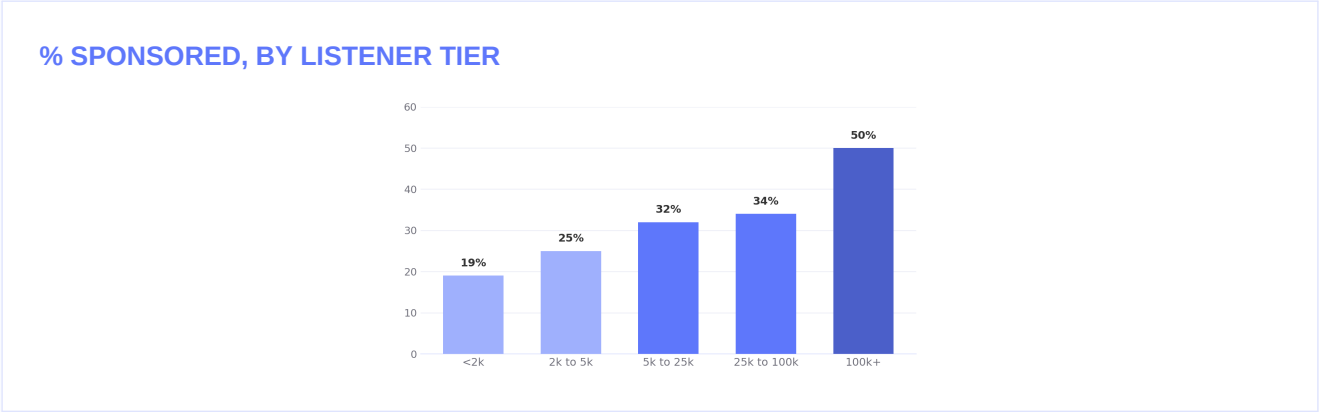


FINDING 03 THE MONETISATION CURVE

Sponsorship climbs with scale.

The biggest shows are far likelier to monetise.

Sponsorship adoption broadly rises with audience size, from roughly one in five of the smallest shows to half of the largest. Advertisers concentrate at the top of the curve.

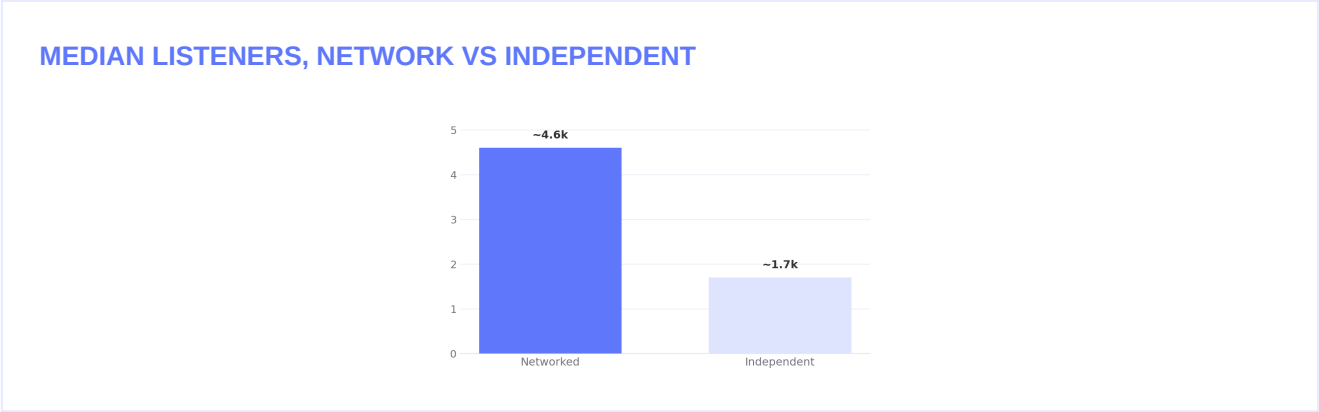


FINDING 04 THE NETWORK PREMIUM

The network premium is large.

Broadcasters and studios dwarf the independent median.

Networked shows post a median audience roughly 2.7 times larger than independents, an association, not a proven effect, since scale and review volume both feed the estimate. The tier is a small minority of shows but commands a disproportionate share of reach.



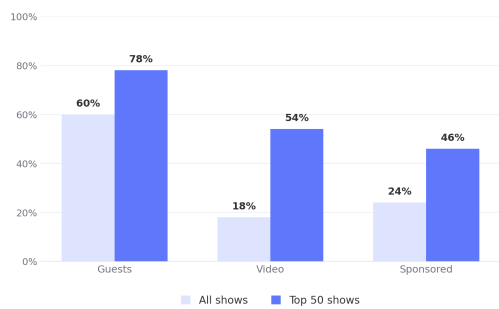
FINDING 05 THE TRIPLE STACK

Winners over-index on format.

Guests, video and sponsorship cluster at the top.

Compared with the catalogue as a whole, the largest shows are far more likely to feature guests, run video and carry sponsors, the strategic "triple stack" of the leaders.

FORMAT SHARE, ALL SHOWS VS TOP 50



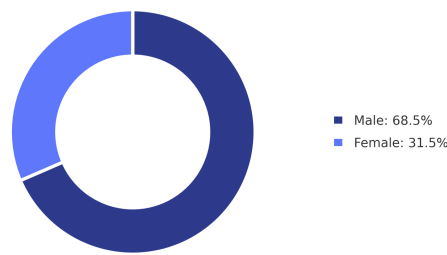
FINDING 06 THE TALENT GAP

A persistent talent gap.

Contributors skew heavily male.

Across individual hosts and contributors, roughly 69% are male and 31% female, a representation gap that maps directly to under-served audiences.

CONTRIBUTORS BY GENDER



— 03 . MARKET STRUCTURE

A long tail, and a very short head.

British podcasting is not a level playing field. It is a steep curve, where a handful of shows absorb most of the attention and thousands of capable productions share what remains.

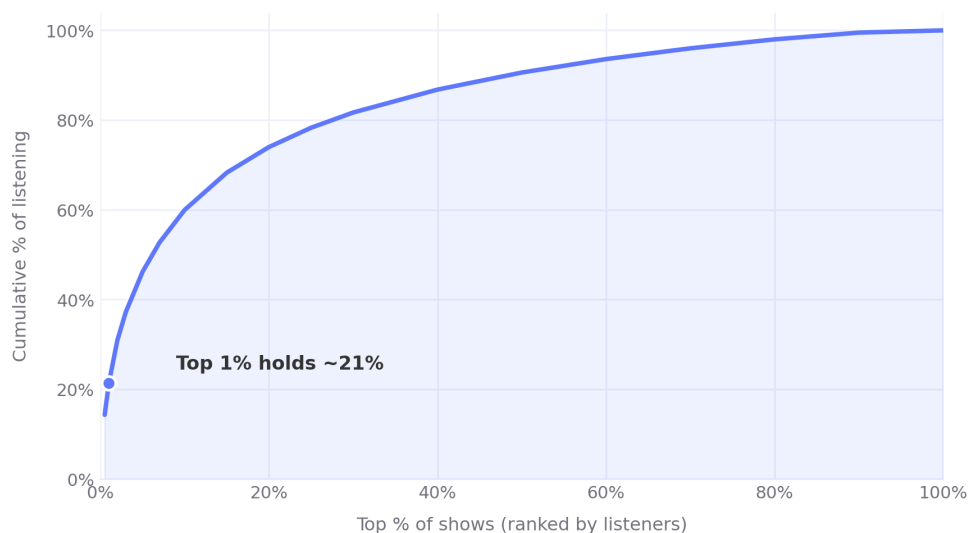
~21% Top 1% share of listening	~46% Top 5% share	~60% Top 10% share
--	-----------------------------	------------------------------

The catalogue is broad, 6,693 active shows, each with a genuine UK following, but listening is anything but evenly spread. The top 1% of titles capture about a fifth of all estimated monthly listening. Widen the lens to the top 5% and the share rises to nearly half; the top 10% account for about six in ten. The bottom half of the catalogue, by contrast, shares barely a tenth of total listening between them.

This is the classic shape of an attention market, and it has a clear strategic reading: reach in UK podcasting is scarce and expensive to manufacture. A show does not drift into the top decile on consistency alone, it gets there through a combination of recognised talent, broad distribution and, frequently, a commercial engine. The middle of the market is large, healthy and creatively rich, but competes for a comparatively thin slice of audience.

CUMULATIVE SHARE OF LISTENING BY TOP % OF SHOWS

The curve is built from the real audience estimates in this dataset. In the interactive edition a slider moves along it; the marked point is the published headline.



CONCENTRATION SIMULATOR

21% of all UK podcast listening is held by the top 1% of shows, about 67 titles. The interactive version of this figure, at millionpodcasts.com, lets a reader set any top share and read the listening it commands.

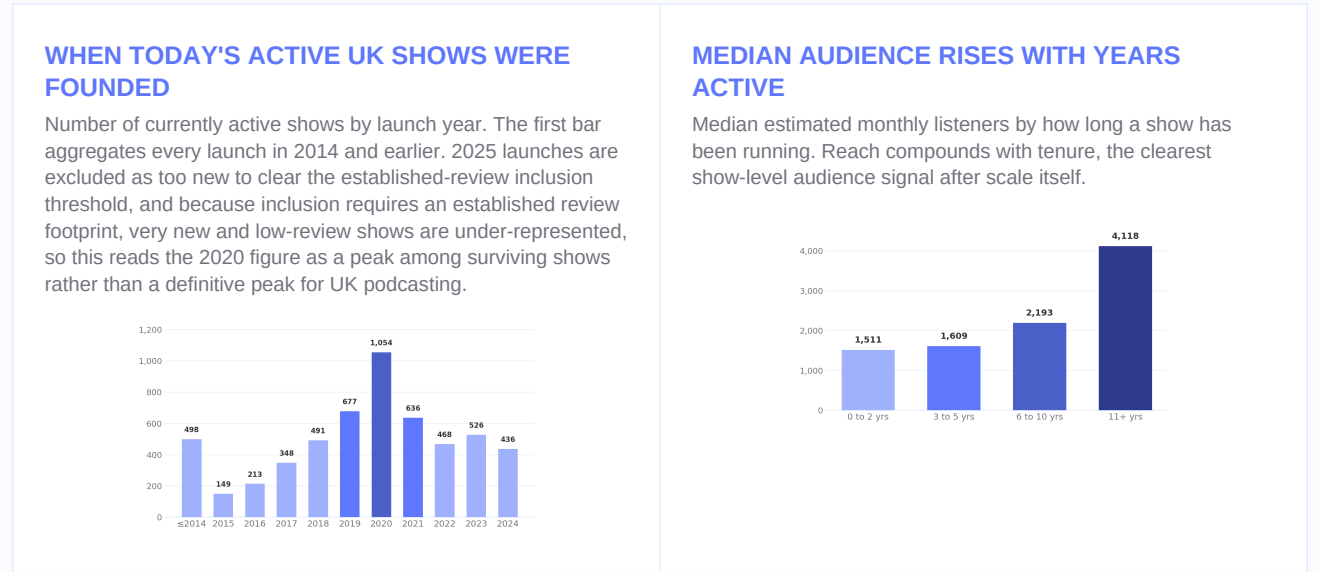
04 . MATURITY & VINTAGE

A market that has aged into its audience.

UK podcasting is not a young medium experimenting at the edges. It is a settled catalogue with a clear founding era, and the longer a show survives, the larger its audience tends to be.

~6 yrs Median time active	2020 Peak launch year	~43% Founded 2019 to 2021	~2.7x Audience edge, oldest vs newest
---	---	---	---

Read by launch year, the catalogue tells a recognisable story. New-show creation climbed steadily through the late 2010s and peaked in 2020, the year the pandemic pushed a wave of new creators into audio. Of shows with an identified launch year, roughly four in ten were founded in the 2019 to 2021 window, about a third of the full catalogue. Since that peak, the rate of new launches surviving into 2026 has cooled overall, running well below the 2020 peak, a pattern consistent with a market past its first-formation phase and now competing on staying power rather than novelty.



The more strategically useful pattern is what tenure does to reach. Group every show by how long it has been running and the median audience climbs cleanly with age: shows active under two years sit near 1,500 monthly listeners, while those running eleven years or more reach roughly 4,100, about a 2.7x audience edge for the longest-lived shows. Unlike episode length, which barely moves audience at all, longevity is one of the few show-level traits that tracks reach strongly across the catalogue.

The relationship is associational rather than proven cause, durable shows are also more likely to be well-resourced and consistently produced, and survivorship means weaker shows drop out of the active set over time. But the read for operators is consistent with the rest of this report: in a market where reach is the scarce resource, compounding matters more than launching. Audience in UK podcasting accrues to shows that keep publishing, which is precisely the advantage incumbents and networks are positioned to defend.

— 05 . INDEPENDENT VS NETWORK

A market of independents, led by its broadcasters.

UK podcasting is still built by independent creators, but its networked tier is anchored not by podcast studios, but by the country's legacy broadcasters and publishers, with the BBC far out in front.

Around 10% of active shows, roughly 645 in total, carry a recognised network or publisher affiliation. The catalogue is still majority independent, built by self-published creators operating without a studio's commercial or production machinery. But the networked minority is anchored by household broadcast names rather than podcast start-ups. The BBC alone accounts for about 145 active shows, far more than any other single publisher, spanning BBC Radio 4, 5 Live, the World Service, BBC Sounds and its nations and local stations. Global, Sky, News UK (The Times and talkSPORT), Bauer and The Guardian follow, alongside dedicated podcast studios such as Goalhanger, Keep It Light Media and Fun Kids.

This tier is also consolidating through deals: Global fully acquired the creator network The Fellas Studios in October 2025, folding it into the Global total shown here, and took a majority stake in Gary Neville's The Overlap in January 2026, though its shows remain independently tagged in this snapshot and are not folded into the 39; the same month The Chernin Group took a minority stake and board seat in Goalhanger, that studio's first outside investment since it was founded in 2014.

The performance gap is real: networked shows post a median audience roughly 2.7 times that of independents (about 4,649 monthly listeners against 1,731). But the tier is not one thing. Commercial studios concentrate resources behind a few high-ceiling shows, while the BBC, the single largest publisher, carries no advertising in the UK at all. That is why the networked tier as a whole shows a lower detected-sponsorship rate than the independent long tail, a measure that misses the dynamically-inserted ads commercial networks rely on, so read it as a floor: here, networks matter above all for reach and production muscle. The strategic implication is significant, the UK network model is about concentrating audience and craft, not selling ads at scale.

The UK's biggest podcast publisher is a public broadcaster that runs no ads. In British podcasting, networks drive reach, not monetisation.

UK networks by show count

RANK	NETWORK	SPECIALISM	SHOWS
01	BBC	Public broadcaster (no UK ads)	145
02	Global	Commercial radio & news	39
03	Sky	Sport & news	21
04	News UK	News & sport	18
05	The Guardian	News & current affairs	11
06	Bauer Media	Radio & music	11
07	Goalhanger	History & current affairs	8
08	Fun Kids	Children's audio	7
09	Keep It Light Media	Comedy & conversation	6

BBC groups the corporation's national, nations and local station output under one publisher; Global, Sky, News UK and Bauer likewise group each company's station and label brands. Network means editorial publisher affiliation, not the hosting or ad-sales representation (such as Acast or Megaphone) that many independent shows use. Counts reflect shows with a recognised affiliation, read from the August 2026 feed snapshot, and are a floor: some network output is untagged, and host-fronted shows are generally shown as Independent. Because the table ranks by show count, it understates publishers that concentrate reach in a few titles. Goalhanger, with eight shows here, produces several of the UK's most-reached podcasts (the "Rest Is..." franchise), and it reports a 14-show network; 8 carry the Goalhanger tag in this snapshot, while others it produces (including The Rest Is History) are tagged independently in the source and counted as independent here. The same undercount affects Global, whose flagship titles (such as The News Agents) are tagged independently rather than to Global here, so Global's count is a floor as well. The publishers shown are the most recognisable consumer names; some specialist networks (for example medical and education publishers) carry comparable show counts but are not listed.

— 06 . MONETISATION & SPONSORSHIP

Where the money is, and where it isn't.

For all the talk of a podcast advertising boom, the British catalogue is still lightly monetised, which is precisely why it represents one of the most attractive untapped inventories in UK media.

~24% Shows carrying sponsorship	2,406 Median listeners, sponsored	1,683 Median listeners, unsponsored	~43% Sponsored audience premium
---	---	---	---

Only about one in four active UK shows currently carries sponsorship or paid placements. The remaining three in four reach real, engaged audiences without yet running advertising. That gap is the opportunity. It is not only a long-tail effect: among the fifty largest shows in the catalogue, around a dozen are independent titles running no detectable advertising. Set aside the BBC programmes beside them, which carry no ads by policy, and even proven hits are not uniformly monetised. A large proportion of the market has demonstrated audience and loyalty but has not been commercialised, a pipeline of inventory for advertisers and a growth runway for networks willing to do the deal-making at scale.

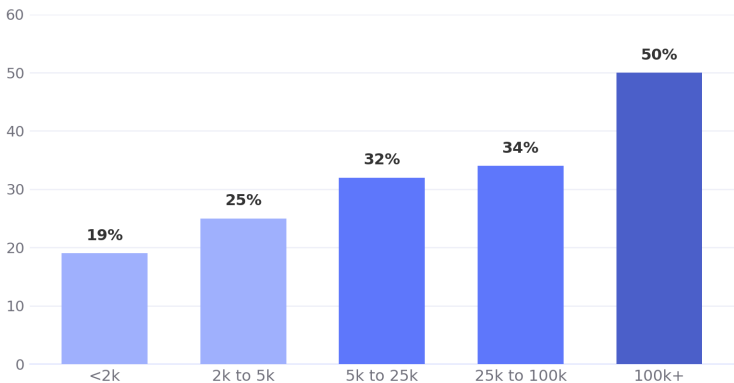
ONE SCOPE NOTE FOR THIS SECTION

Monetisation here means detected advertising, the sponsor reads and paid placements visible in a show's public metadata. Subscription, membership and live-event revenue are real and sometimes substantial, but they sit outside this dataset, so a show shown as unsponsored here may still earn directly from its audience.

Monetisation also tracks scale. Sponsorship adoption broadly rises with audience, from roughly one in five of the smallest shows to half of the largest, and sponsored shows post a median audience around 43% larger than unsponsored ones. The causation runs both ways: bigger shows attract advertisers, and advertiser relationships fund the production and promotion that grow audiences further. For PR and media agencies, the read is that UK sponsorship is still concentrated at the top, leaving a deep mid-tier open to brands willing to move earlier.

SPONSORSHIP RISES WITH AUDIENCE SIZE

Share of shows carrying sponsorship, by listener tier. The top (100k+) tier rests on only ~34 shows, so read that bar as indicative.



Sizing the unsold inventory

The clearest way to size the prize is to look at what has not been sold. Of the roughly 5,118 UK shows running no sponsorship, about 4,563 are independent and could carry advertising tomorrow; the other 555 sit within networks, the ad-free BBC the largest single block, though most of the rest sits not with the big commercial groups but across a long tail of smaller and specialist publishers, inventory that is in practice far more open to advertisers than the ad-free BBC.

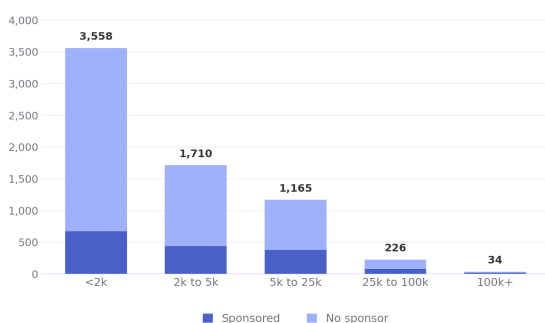
A large share of that independent pool already commands real audiences: about 1,865 reach 2,000+ monthly listeners and roughly 695 reach 5,000+. That last figure is deliberately strict: 954 unsponsored shows clear 5,000 listeners in all, but 259 sit within networks, leaving 695 independents an advertiser could genuinely buy, proven, engaged inventory that has simply never been commercialised. The commercially addressable core alone runs to roughly 17 million modelled monthly listeners, about 60% of all independent listening in the catalogue, a sum of per-show audiences, so a listener who follows several shows is counted in each, meaning this is duplicated listener-reach across shows rather than 17 million distinct people. It is not a lower-quality remainder, these are live, established shows reaching the same audience tiers as their sponsored peers.

PROVEN AUDIENCE, NO ADVERTISER: ~695 SHOWS

Independent UK shows already reach 5,000+ modelled monthly listeners yet carry no detectable sponsor, engaged inventory that has never been sold. Widen the lens to 2,000+ listeners and the independent unsold pool is roughly 1,865 shows.

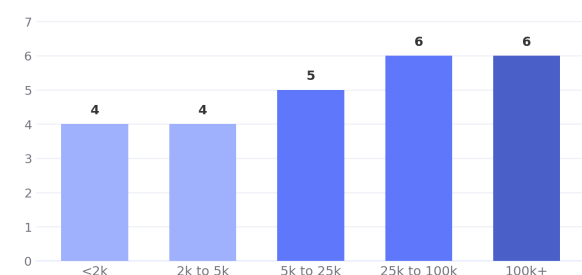
MONETISED VS UNMONETISED SHOWS, BY AUDIENCE SIZE

Every listener tier split into shows that carry sponsorship and shows that do not. The lighter band is every unsponsored show, including the ad-free BBC, so it runs wider than the independent inventory an advertiser could buy.



ADVERTISER SLOTS PER SHOW RISE WITH SCALE

Median number of unique sponsors carried by a sponsored show, by listener tier. Bigger shows run deeper, multi-advertiser inventory.



The inventory deepens as shows grow, the largest sponsored shows carry a median of six advertisers each against four in the smallest tier, so winning a big show means competing for one of many rotating slots, not a single exclusive. Networked shows are not automatically the richer target: the tier's biggest member, the BBC, runs no UK advertising at all, so networked shows show a lower detected-sponsorship rate than independents (14% versus 25%), though detection reads show-notes and misses the dynamically-inserted and pre-roll advertising commercial networks rely on, so that gap understates how much networks actually monetise rather than proving they sell fewer ads. The fastest commercial gains

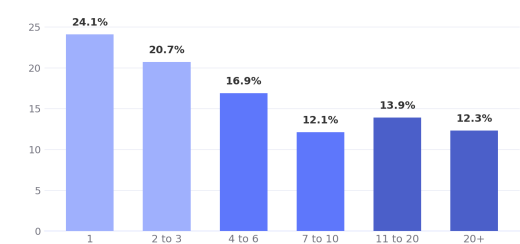
are likely to come from ad-sales houses and commercial studios moving on the engaged independent mid-tier before it is contested.

Sponsorship depth among sponsored shows

Where sponsorship does run, it tends to run deep. Across the 1,575 sponsored UK shows, the median sponsored title carries 4 distinct sponsor names over its life (top quartile 11+). A handful of review and interview shows list dozens to several hundred, but for those formats the field captures brands discussed on air rather than paid placements, so the median is the figure to trust, meaning the commercial inventory inside an active sponsored show is rarely a single anchor brand but a rotating set of advertisers across episodes. For media buyers, that is a market structure where competing for slots in mid-tier shows already running ads is often a faster path than convincing an unsponsored show to onboard advertising for the first time.

SPONSOR DEPTH PER SPONSORED SHOW

Number of distinct sponsor names associated with each sponsored show over its life. Read the upper bands with care: for review and interview formats this field also captures brands discussed on air rather than paid placements, so the 20+ band is inflated. The median of 4 is the robust figure.

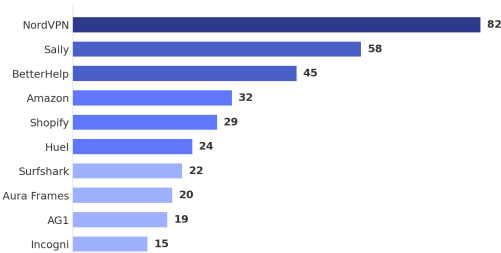


Who is buying the inventory

The advertiser names recur, and they cluster hard. Privacy and VPN brands are the single largest presence in UK podcasting. NordVPN alone appears across 82 shows, and the wider Nord Security family, NordVPN, its Saily eSIM brand, Surfshark and Incogni, together appears on 131 distinct shows, more than any other advertiser group. Behind them sit the mental-health platform BetterHelp (45 shows), e-commerce and cloud tooling (Shopify 29, Amazon 32), supplements and wellness (Huel 24, AG1 19), and banking and fintech.

MOST-CITED ADVERTISERS IN UK PODCASTING

Number of UK shows each advertiser appears on, across the catalogue's sponsor records. Counts are show appearances, not ad spend. Privacy and VPN brands lead by a wide margin.

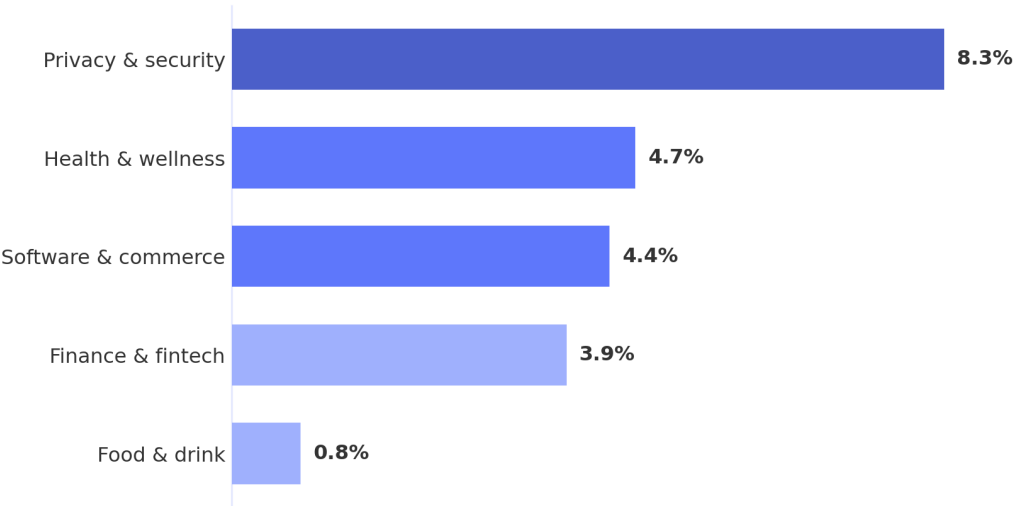


These are not scattershot placements: shows carrying one of the leading direct-response brands run a median audience roughly four times that of the typical sponsored show, near 10,000 monthly listeners against about 2,400, so the biggest advertisers concentrate their budgets in the biggest shows and leave the engaged mid-tier largely uncontested. The pattern is a small set of direct-response category leaders cycling across the same shows, with comparatively thin representation from traditional consumer-brand advertisers, itself a signal of how much brand-budget headroom the channel still holds.

Stepping back from individual brands, the advertiser base clusters into a handful of direct-response categories. Privacy and security tools are the single largest category, appearing on about 8% of all sponsored UK shows, ahead of health and wellness, software and commerce, finance, and food and drink. Much of that privacy spend traces to one corporate family: NordVPN, Saily, Incogni and Surfshark are effectively the entire category, a concentration that shapes how the whole category's pricing and availability move.

THE CATEGORIES BUYING UK PODCAST INVENTORY

Share of sponsored shows carrying at least one advertiser in each category. Categories count only nationally-recurring advertisers (brands appearing across ten or more shows), which excludes one-off names and brands merely discussed on air.



The demand base is thin as well as concentrated: the ten most-cited advertisers appear on just 225 sponsored shows (distinct shows; a show may carry several), about one in seven, while the catalogue records more than 13,000 distinct sponsor-name strings in total (only lightly normalised, and the field also captures brands merely discussed or reviewed on a show, not only paid sponsors, so this figure overstates distinct advertisers), a very long tail of one-off and regional deals sitting beneath the direct-response leaders. Filter to brands that recur at national scale and the genuine advertiser pool is strikingly shallow: only about 30 brands appear across ten or more shows.

THE WHOLE RECURRING ADVERTISER BASE: ~30 BRANDS

Only about thirty brands buy space across ten or more UK shows. That is the entire demand side of this market, shallow enough that a single corporate family, Nord, anchors the largest category on its own. For a channel whose audience runs to tens of millions of modelled monthly listens, that is a very small set of buyers, and the clearest single measure of how much category headroom the medium still holds.

07 . ENGAGEMENT & DISCOVERABILITY

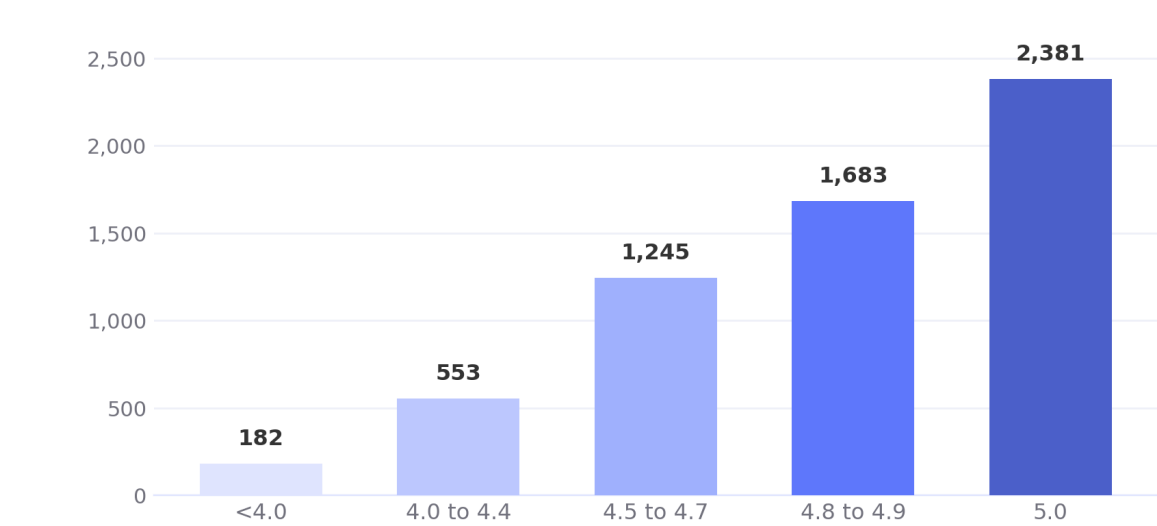
Ratings don't separate the field, reviews do.

UK listeners rate the shows they choose remarkably highly. That makes star ratings a poor differentiator, and pushes the real signal of momentum onto review volume.

The average UK show holds an Apple rating of around 4.8 out of 5, with a median close to a perfect score. Nearly two in five of rated shows (39%) sit at a perfect 5.0. When almost everyone scores highly, the score itself stops being informative. A high rating is table stakes in British podcasting, not a competitive edge.

RATINGS ARE COMPRESSED AT THE TOP

Distribution of active UK shows by Apple rating band. The mass sits at 4.8 and above, leaving little room for differentiation. Base: n = 6,044 shows with a computed rating band.



Review volume tracks audience size

The meaningful signal is review volume, the count of listeners motivated enough to leave feedback. Review counts strongly track audience size across the full catalogue (R-squared of about 0.90 in log space; this correlation is substantially mechanical, since review volume is itself an input to the modelled listener estimate, so it is not independent evidence), and they vary enormously: from a median of only a few dozen UK reviews to tens of thousands for the most-reviewed shows in the country.

REVIEWS TRACK REACH

Estimated monthly listeners vs UK review count (log scales, top shows). The plotted top-shows subset correlates more tightly (R-squared about 0.98 in log space) than the full catalogue (R-squared about 0.90, the figure cited in the text). Plotted points are the leaderboard-eligible majority-UK shows with a current review count; larger UK-made shows with mainly international audiences (No Such Thing As A Fish, The Rest Is History) sit in the catalogue but outside this majority-UK view.



The relationship is associational and partly mutually reinforcing: review volume is one of several public signals used to model the listener estimate itself, so the two move together by construction as well as by behaviour. Review volume, not the star rating attached to it, is also the discoverability flywheel: it is associated with platform ranking, social proof and the algorithmic surfacing that compounds a show's reach.

— 08 . PLATFORM & DISTRIBUTION

Spotify is universal. Video is the open frontier.

Distribution strategy across the UK catalogue is lopsided: near-total presence on the major audio platform, but strikingly thin adoption of video, the format this data marks as the clearest distribution gap.

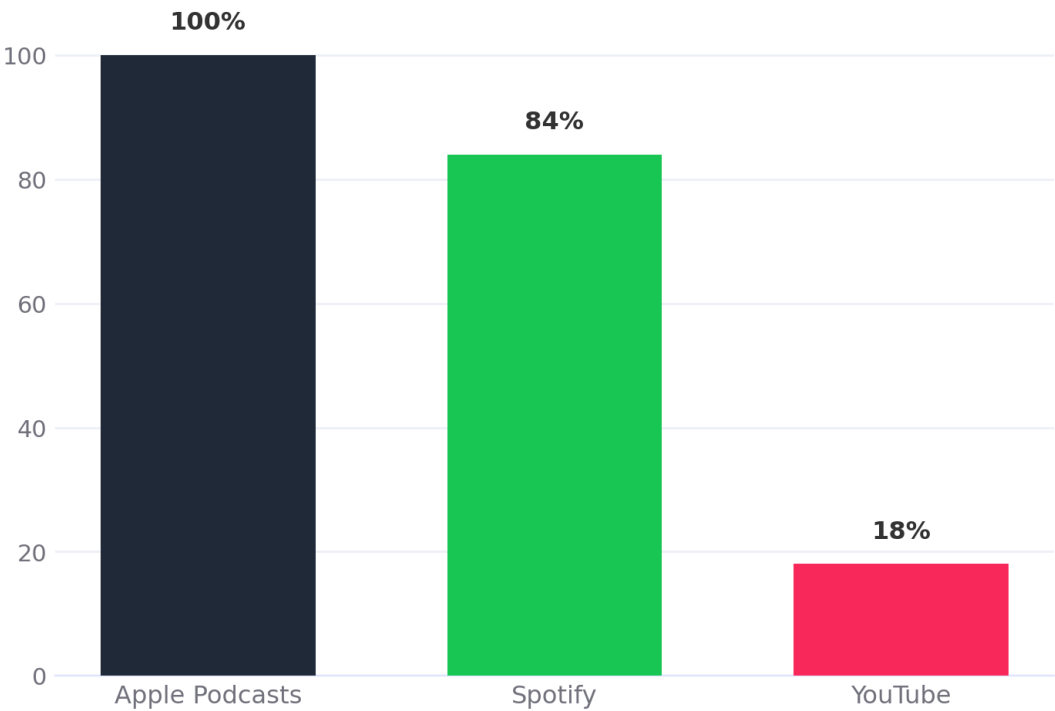
Read these shares with one thing in mind: Apple sits at 100% by construction, not by coincidence. The catalogue is built from Apple's public listings, because a UK-dominant Apple review footprint is the study's inclusion criterion. Spotify's ~84% is the genuine result, more than four in five UK shows keep a Spotify home alongside their Apple listing, making dual-platform audio distribution the de facto standard for any serious British podcast. Read this as distribution presence, not share of listening: a Spotify listing marks where a show is available, not where the listening happens; "has a Spotify listing" and "share of UK listening" are different measures.

The standout gap is video. Only about 18% of UK shows maintain a linked YouTube channel surfaced alongside the audio feed, a measure of distribution format, not of audience consumption. It is best read as a conservative floor: a show that posts clips without a channel linked in its public feed metadata is not captured here, so genuine video activity may run somewhat higher. One UK-specific platform sits outside this picture by design: BBC Sounds, the corporation's own on-demand home, is not an open, cross-catalogue distribution surface and so cannot be measured here the way Apple, Spotify and YouTube can, a gap worth naming given the BBC's scale in this market; because this catalogue is anchored on Apple review activity, it structurally under-weights BBC Sounds-first and download-first shows in both count and reach.

Even read generously, the gap between near-universal audio distribution and the roughly 18% of shows carrying video is wide, and those that have made the move post a median audience around 58% larger than audio-only peers (about 2,697 monthly listeners against 1,705). Video is not merely another upload destination; it is a discovery engine, opening a show to YouTube's recommendation and search surface. For the four in five not yet there, it is the clearest distribution gap left to close.

AUDIO IS SOLVED. VIDEO IS THE OPEN LEVER.

Share of active UK shows with a confirmed presence on each platform. We restrict this chart to the three platform-verified signals the catalogue identifies reliably: Apple Podcasts (the catalogue baseline, hence ~100%), Spotify, and YouTube. Social-media handles (Twitter/X, Facebook, Instagram, LinkedIn) are not shown because coverage of those fields is incomplete and would understate true presence.



THE GAP, STATED PLAINLY

About 18% of UK shows publish a YouTube channel linked in their feed. In this dataset the shows that carry linked video reach materially larger audiences than audio-only peers, so linked video reads as additive reach on top of a show's audio base rather than a substitute for it. The adoption gap, not the audio distribution question, is where the addressable upside in this market sits.

— 09 . CONTENT & FORMAT

The triple stack the leaders share.

British podcasting is a deep, committed market with a clear preferred format, and the shows at the top combine three structural choices the rest of the catalogue does not.

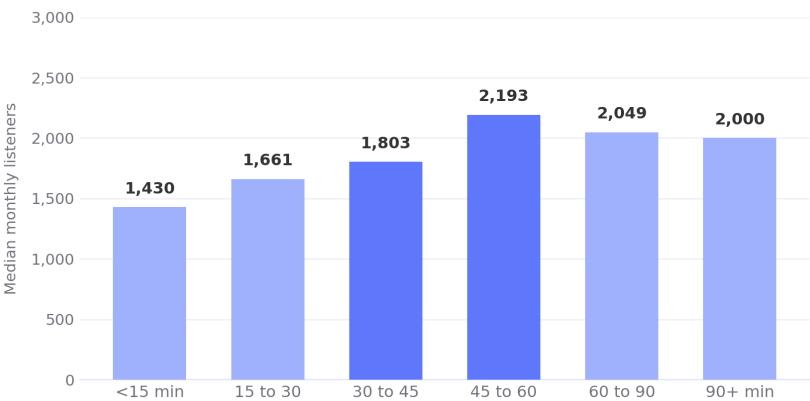
The median active UK show has published well over a hundred episodes, with an average above two hundred, evidence of a creator base that sustains output over years, not weeks. The median show has been active for around five to six years, and roughly three-quarters of shows with an identified launch year (74%) have been running five years or longer; this is a mature catalogue, not a recent surge. The typical episode runs ~40 minutes (56% sit in the 30 to 60 minute band), pointing to a market that has settled into long-form conversation as its default length. Format is dominated by talk: around 60% of shows feature guests, making the interview-and-discussion model the backbone of the catalogue.

Episode length is not a growth lever

One thing that does not separate shows is episode length itself. Median monthly audience varies only about 1.5x across the length bands the catalogue settles into, from roughly 1,430 monthly listeners for the shortest shows to a peak of about 2,200 in the 45 to 60 minute band, with the longest formats sitting slightly below that peak, a narrow spread next to the enormous gap across the audience curve itself. Episode length is a stylistic choice, not a growth lever, which reinforces the report's central thesis that reach, not format or volume, is the scarce resource in this market.

MEDIAN AUDIENCE BY EPISODE LENGTH (VARIES ONLY ~1.5X)

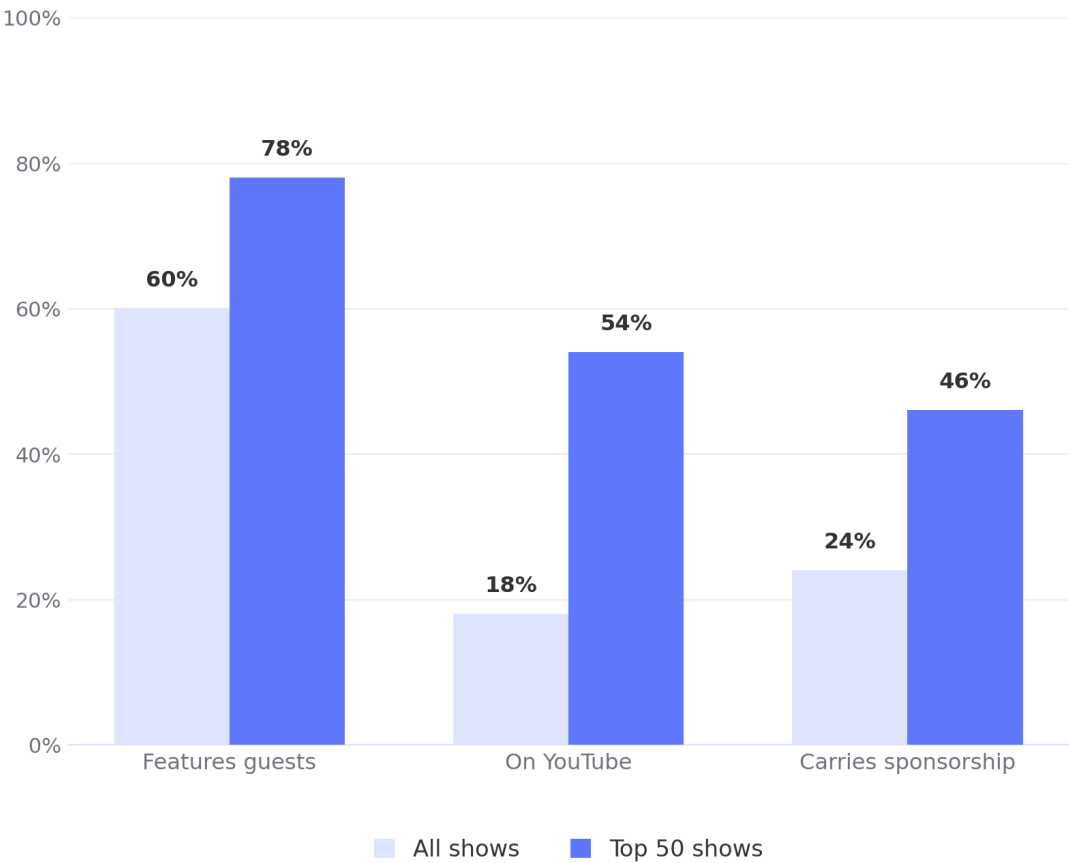
Median monthly listeners for shows in each length band. The spread across bands is about 1.5x, against roughly 190x between the median show (about 1,815 monthly listeners) and the most-listened title.



But the leaders are distinguished by a "triple stack": they over-index sharply on guests, video and sponsorship together. Where the catalogue as a whole features guests ~60% of the time, the top shows do so far more often (~78%); video presence roughly triples; and sponsorship nearly doubles. The takeaway for creators is that consistency and the guest dynamic are the reliable structural base, but combining them with video distribution and a commercial engine is what separates the top of the market from the middle.

THE TRIPLE STACK, ALL SHOWS VS THE TOP TIER

Share of shows featuring guests, video and sponsorship: the whole catalogue compared with the 50 largest shows.



10 . WHERE HOSTS ARE BASED

Where UK podcasters live, with London at the centre.

Among the British shows whose hosts or co-hosts resolve to a UK location, podcasting talent clusters tightly around the capital, with meaningful but far smaller hubs across England's cities and the devolved nations. Location here reflects where the people behind these shows are based, not where the podcast is recorded or produced.

Of the active shows where at least one host has an identifiable UK base, England accounts for the overwhelming majority, with Scotland, Wales and Northern Ireland together representing a modest share. Within England, the pull of London is gravitational: the capital alone is the home city for over two-fifths (~42%) of these shows, more than ten times Manchester, the next-largest hub.

THE HOME NATIONS

Active shows grouped by their host's home nation. England's dominance reflects both population and the concentration of UK podcasting talent in the south-east. Base: 2,739 shows with an identifiable UK nation.



The pattern mirrors the wider creative economy. Commissioning networks, talent agencies, studios and advertising decision-makers concentrate in London, and the people who host podcasts cluster in the same gravity. Yet the regional pools that do exist, with Manchester the clear leader and Bristol and Glasgow level behind it, then further clusters in Birmingham, Leeds, Cambridge and Edinburgh, are not incidental: they represent durable local talent pools that networks looking for distinctive, regionally-rooted voices increasingly court.

CITIES WHERE UK PODCASTERS CLUSTER

Top UK cities where podcast hosts and co-hosts are based, shown as a share of UK-based shows (n~2,739). London's lead over every regional hub is more than tenfold.



11 . BEHIND & IN FRONT OF THE MIC

The audience doesn't look like the people making the shows.

Two questions worth asking of any UK podcast: who's behind it, and who's actually listening? In this catalogue, the answers diverge sharply, a structural mismatch with implications for both commissioning and ad targeting.

FEMALE SHARE: CREATORS VS AUDIENCE, A ~12-POINT GAP

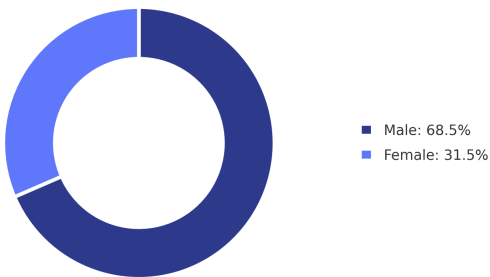
Female share of identifiable individual contributors compared with the average UK show's reported female listener share (across shows with audience data, ~69% of the catalogue).



Analysed at the level of individual hosts and contributors, roughly 69% are male and 31% female. But the picture flips when you look at who is on the other end of the headphones: across the 4,640+ shows with reported audience data, the average UK podcast's audience is ~44% female, a gap of over twelve points between who is making the content and who is consuming it.

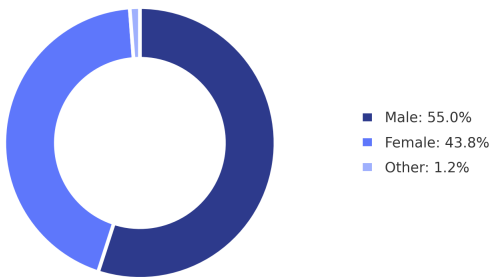
CONTRIBUTORS BY GENDER

Share of identifiable individual hosts and contributors across the active UK catalogue.



AVERAGE AUDIENCE GENDER MIX

Mean reported audience composition across the ~4,640 UK shows with listener-gender data (~69% of the catalogue).

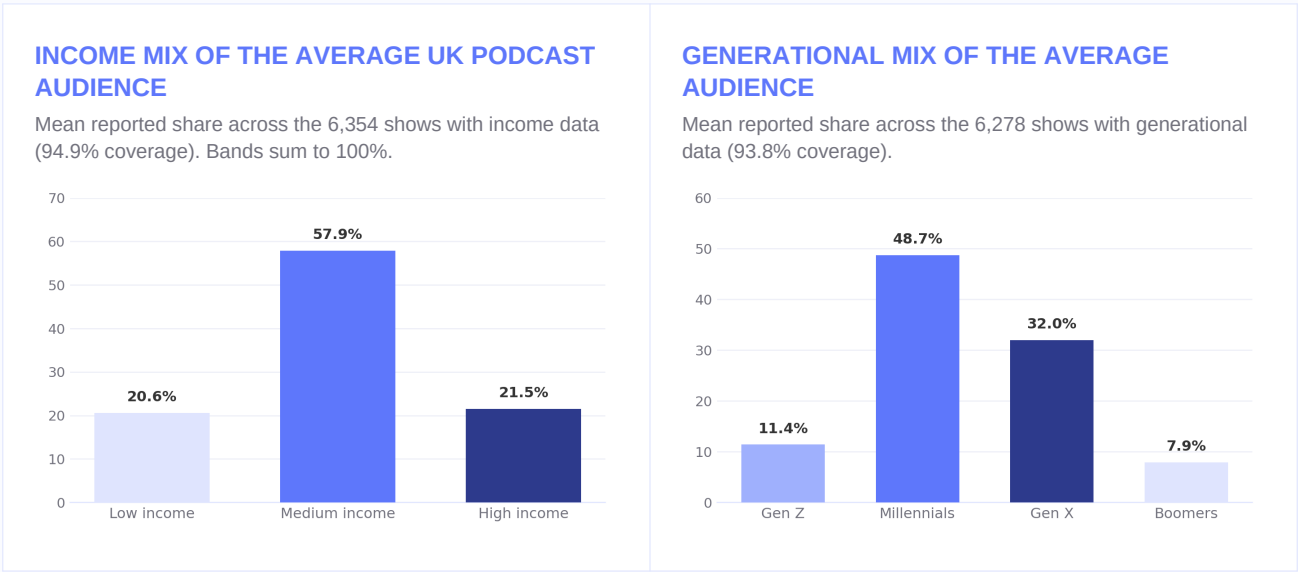


That mismatch is one of the most actionable findings in this report. For commissioners, it suggests a structural undersupply of female-fronted shows relative to female listener appetite, the shows that close the gap are positioned to reach listeners the rest of the market is not actively serving. For advertisers, it means audience composition cannot be inferred from who is hosting; targeting on creator profile alone systematically mis-prices reach. One caveat sits underneath this: the 44% female audience figure is a modelled composition profile, not surveyed listener data, so treat it as a directional signal rather than a precise measurement.

11B . WHO IS ACTUALLY LISTENING

Income, generation: the typical UK podcast audience profile.

Beyond gender, the source data carries reported audience composition by income band and generation for about 94% of UK shows. The average composition is consistent enough across the catalogue to give a useful "shape" of UK podcast demand, and useful for advertisers targeting by audience type rather than by raw size.



The typical UK podcast audience is middle-income (57.9% medium, 21.5% high-income and 20.6% low-income) and millennial-anchored: Millennials average half the listener base, Gen X a third, and Gen Z and Boomers split the remainder. The pattern is consistent across shows of very different sizes, which suggests it reflects the underlying shape of UK podcast consumption rather than the audience of any single tier. For brands choosing the channel, podcasts in this market are most efficient when the target overlaps with that middle-income millennial-and-Gen-X core, and least efficient where the brief calls for Gen Z reach at scale, a group that forms only a small share of these audiences.

— 12 . TOP 10 BY APPLE-ANCHORED REACH

The shows that anchor the ecosystem.

The largest shows in this Apple-review-anchored ranking share a recognisable playbook, bankable talent, long publishing histories and, usually, a commercial model. Because the ranking is anchored to Apple review data, it leans toward long-running, audio-first entertainment: seven of these ten are comedy, and the news, sport and video-native titles that lead other rankings do not appear here, for the reasons set out below.

How to read this ranking

This top 10 reflects the UK-anchored audience cut (the catalogue's median UK review share is ~77%), so a small number of globally large shows whose audience base is not UK-dominant fall outside this set by design. It ranks shows by a reach model weighted toward Apple-ratings signals, which systematically under-ranks download-first, YouTube-first and BBC Sounds shows, so download-first and YouTube-first titles (for example Goalhanger's *The Rest Is Politics* and *The Rest Is History*, or *Newscast* and *The News Agents*) sit lower here or fall outside the set.

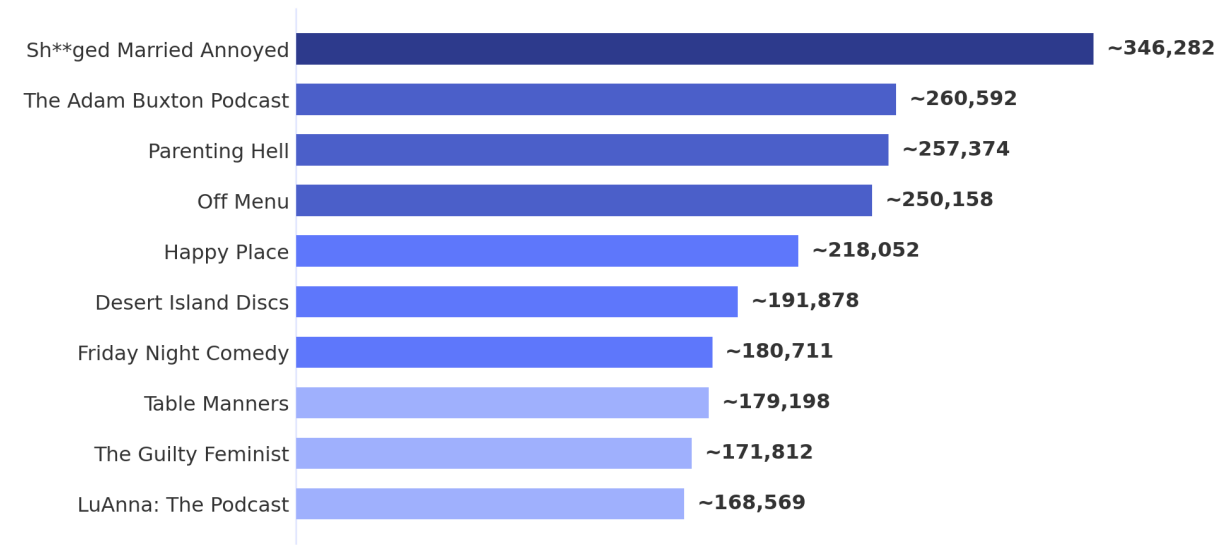
Globally large shows whose audience is not UK-dominant by reach, *The Diary of a CEO* among them, are excluded by design, not overlooked, even where the UK is their single largest review market. Read this as an Apple-anchored, modelled reach ranking, not a direct audience measurement. It ranks only shows whose Apple reviews are majority-UK; the catalogue-wide charts elsewhere describe the full 6,693-show set, which includes some shows with a larger non-UK review share.

Two entries here, *Off Menu* and *The Guilty Feminist*, qualify by UK registration but carried no review count in this export, so both their review figures and the modelled listener estimates that set their rank come from the prior snapshot rather than current. All figures are the August 2026 data snapshot; episode counts in particular keep growing after it.

The Video column reflects whether a YouTube channel is linked in the show's feed, the same linked-in-feed signal as the catalogue-wide ~18% figure. Larger shows link video more often, so the rate here runs higher; shows that publish video without a linked channel may not be flagged.

MODELLED MONTHLY LISTENERS (TOP 10)

Modelled monthly estimates, rounded and directional rather than audited.



#	SHOW	LISTENERS PER MONTH	UK REVIEWS	EPISODES	PUBLISHER	VIDEO
1	Sh**ged Married Annoyed	~346k	~45k	158	Avalon	No
2	The Adam Buxton Podcast	~261k	~20k	188	Independent	Yes
3	Parenting Hell	~257k	~19k	673	Keep It Light Media	No
4	Off Menu	~250k	~18k	267	Plosive	Yes
5	Happy Place	~218k	~15k	397	Independent	Yes
6	Desert Island Discs	~192k	~13k	698	BBC	No
7	Friday Night Comedy	~181k	~12k	332	BBC	No
8	Table Manners	~179k	~12k	315	Independent	No
9	The Guilty Feminist	~172k	~11k	343	Independent	Yes
10	LuAnna: The Podcast	~169k	~11k	445	Global	Yes

Listener figures are modelled monthly estimates, rounded and directional rather than audited. Show titles abbreviated for presentation.

— 13 . KEY INSIGHTS

Ten things to take away.

01 **Reach is the scarce resource, not content**

With the top 10% of shows holding around six in ten of all listening, the UK's constraint is not catalogue size but distribution. Strategies that manufacture discovery outperform strategies that simply add episodes.

02 **Independence is the norm, consolidation the trend**

Around 90% of shows are network-free, yet networked shows run roughly 2.7 times larger, and the single biggest publisher of all is the BBC. Expect the networked share of the top tier to keep rising as broadcasters and studios consolidate.

03 **The market is under-monetised by design, not failure**

Roughly three in four shows run no sponsorship despite real audiences. This is unclaimed inventory, the clearest near-term opportunity for advertisers and ad-sales networks.

04 **Video is the biggest open lever**

Only about 18% are on YouTube, but those that are skew materially larger. For most UK shows, adding video is the clearest distribution gap to close in 2026, an association with larger audiences, not a proven lift.

05 **Star ratings are noise; review volume is signal**

With an average near 4.8, ratings don't separate shows. Review counts, which strongly track audience size across the full catalogue (R-squared about 0.90 in log space), are the metric that most consistently moves with momentum.

06 **London concentrates the talent pool**

Over two-fifths (~42%) of identifiable shows have a London-based host. Networks seeking differentiated, regionally-rooted voices will increasingly look to Manchester, Bristol and Glasgow.

07 **Sponsorship and scale reinforce each other**

Sponsored shows are larger, and larger shows attract sponsors. Breaking into that loop early, before a show is obviously big, is where advertiser value is highest.

08 **The leaders run a triple stack**

Guests, video and sponsorship cluster together at the top. The interview model is the base; combining it with video and a commercial engine is what separates leaders from the middle.

09 **The talent gap behind the mic is real**

Contributors skew roughly 69% male. Under-represented creators map to under-served audiences, a commissioning opportunity as much as an equity issue.

10 **There is no single path to the top**

The leaderboard mixes networked and independent, sponsored and not, video and audio-only. The constant is accumulated trust, review depth compounded over years.

— 14 . TRY IT

Score your show against the UK Top-10 playbook.

Each trait is informed by how strongly it is associated with larger audiences in the UK data. In the interactive edition these are toggles that total a score out of 100; in print they are shown with their weights so a reader can add up their own.

THE LEADER'S CHECKLIST	WEIGHT
Backed by a podcast network	+18
Hundreds of genuine listener reviews	+18
Running for 6+ years	+14
Distributed on YouTube (video)	+14
Carries sponsorship or paid placements	+12
Features regular guests	+12
Published 100+ episodes	+8
Also present on Spotify	+4
Maximum score	100

How to read your total

0 to 30 Long tail	30 to 55 Mid-market	55 to 80 Contender	80 to 100 Top tier
----------------------	------------------------	-----------------------	-----------------------

DISCLAIMER

This scorecard is a directional self-assessment, not a prediction. It reflects associations observed in this dataset between strategic choices and audience size; it does not forecast any individual show's reach or growth. Several of the largest UK shows score mid-range here, not because they are small but because they skip one or two of these traits, some carry no advertising, some are audio-only, so the score reads as a growth-trait checklist rather than a ranking of reach. Many shows that tick every box remain in the long tail. Strategy and execution still matter most.

— 15 . STRATEGIC IMPLICATIONS

What this means for the people building UK podcast media.

The same dataset reads differently depending on where you sit in the value chain. Four perspectives.

For creators

Distribution beats volume

Adding episodes alone doesn't appear to lift shows up a curve this steep. In the data, the leaders tend to combine a video presence, high review counts and guest cross-promotion. YouTube is associated with larger audiences, treat it as a discovery surface rather than an afterthought.

For advertisers

Buy the mid-tier early

With three in four shows uncommercialised, the engaged mid-market is open and comparatively cheap. Shows posting strong review growth tend to be the ones rising up the audience curve in the data, making them sponsorship candidates worth identifying before they reach the apex.

For networks

Consolidate the apex, scout the regions

The networked footprint in the UK is concentration, not breadth, studios back a few high-ceiling shows rather than spreading bets. Networked shows are associated with audiences roughly 2.7 times those of independents; the next clusters appear increasingly outside London.

For PR & agencies

Pitch on reviews, not ratings

When briefing clients on which UK shows matter, review volume and video presence are the observable signals most strongly associated with reach. Map target audiences to the under-represented formats the market currently overlooks.

— CONCLUSION

An independent market entering its consolidation phase.

British podcasting in 2026 is large, mature and creatively independent, built by thousands of committed creators rather than a handful of studios. But it is also a steeply concentrated attention market, where reach is scarce and the rewards of distribution compound quickly.

The forces that will shape the next phase are already visible in the data: a professional network tier consolidating the top with audiences several times larger, a video frontier much of the market has yet to cross, and a deep pool of engaged, un-monetised audience waiting to be commercialised.

THE BOTTOM LINE

The shows, and the businesses, that move first on those three fronts will define the British podcast landscape of 2027 and beyond.

— 16 . METHODOLOGY

How this report was built.

A note on scope, definitions and limitations, so the findings can be interpreted, cited and trusted with confidence.

SCOPE	CATALOGUE	SNAPSHOT	UNIT
Active UK podcasts only	6,693 shows	August 2026, monthly	Show-level, deduplicated

01 Scope and definition of a UK podcast

This report analyses **6,693 unique active UK podcasts** drawn from a large-scale cross-platform podcast intelligence dataset. Inclusion covers two groups: the 6,030 shows whose leading Apple review market is the UK (an established review footprint, most though not all carrying more than ten UK reviews) and 663 UK-registered shows that carry no Apple review count. Together they represent the established, reviewed British catalogue rather than a census of every UK podcast. A show is treated as UK-based chiefly on its Apple review market, with UK registration (which reflects host location) used for shows that carry no review count; a show with some overseas hosts can still qualify as British. A UK-anchoring check on the same sample confirms the catalogue is genuinely domestic: the median show draws about 77% of its Apple ratings from UK listeners, and the share remains close to 77% across the largest shows by audience. Because inclusion requires this established UK review footprint, the sample is the reviewed, established catalogue and excludes the long tail of very small, new or hobbyist shows; reported rates such as monetisation, video presence, liveness and average ratings therefore probably run higher than a full census of every UK podcast would show. Apple is only one of several UK podcast platforms, so this Apple-review-defined frame maps the established, review-active supply side rather than total UK listening.

02 How records are resolved

Where a show has several contributor records, show-level attributes are resolved to a single record before analysis. For the small group of shows qualifying on UK registration, contributor records occasionally disagree on country; these are resolved consistently, and the alternative resolution would move the catalogue total by about 20 shows out of 6,693.

03 Snapshot date and liveness

This report is a snapshot of the UK podcast ecosystem as of **August 2026**. A podcast is counted as active if it had published at least one episode during 2026 at the time of the snapshot. The entire analysed catalogue meets this bar, so all figures describe the live, currently-publishing UK ecosystem rather than a historical archive. As a freshness check on the snapshot, about 78% of these shows published a new episode within the most recent 90 days, and 59% within the most recent 30, confirming the catalogue is genuinely live rather than a back-catalogue of dormant feeds.

04 Deduplication

Because a single show can be associated with several hosts, producers or contributors, the underlying records hold multiple entries per show. All audience, performance and platform metrics are deduplicated to a single observation per show before analysis. Only contributor-representation measures, such as the gender breakdown, are analysed at the level of individual people, since collapsing them would erase the very distinction being measured.

05 How tenure is measured

Tenure is measured from a show's first known launch year to the snapshot date, so "running five years or longer" means launched in 2021 or earlier; the median catalogue tenure on this basis is six years.

06 How are audience estimates modelled

Audience figures throughout this report are **point estimates of unique monthly reach** (a monthly audience figure, not a weekly one), modelled from aggregated platform and engagement signals, Apple ratings volume, episode cadence, distribution footprint and time on platform, and adopted as the conservative reading of audience size for each show. They are not audited download counts; no consumer-facing podcast measurement system produces audited downloads at scale across an entire national catalogue.

07 How reliable are the estimates

The estimates are most reliable as relative comparisons, the ordering of shows and the magnitude of the gaps between tiers. They are less reliable as exact absolute totals: a figure of 50,000 monthly listeners should be read as a band rather than a precise count, while a show estimated at twice another's audience is, with high confidence, materially larger. All values are presented rounded to reflect this uncertainty, and per-show audience estimates are summed only where the report explicitly reports an aggregate reach figure (such as the addressable-inventory total), and such sums count a listener once per show they follow rather than as a unique-people total.

08 How reliable are the demographic figures

Audience composition by gender, income and generation is reported as a **modelled audience profile** produced by MillionPodcasts' proprietary audience model rather than a listener survey, and should be read as indicative of the distributions show owners and advertisers see, rather than as a precise census of individual listeners. For a minority of shows whose Apple-review footprint is light relative to their true reach, typically Spotify-first or otherwise off-Apple titles, the estimate is extrapolated from review volume and off-Apple distribution signals, so their individual ranks should be read as indicative rather than exact. Because several of these signals, notably distribution footprint, are themselves inputs to the estimate, findings that compare audiences across distribution breadth, including the video premium, the network premium and the platform-presence results, partly reflect how the estimate is constructed and should be read as associations rather than independent effects.

09 How are concentration figures calculated

The concentration simulator ranks every show by modelled monthly listeners and reports the cumulative share of listening held by the chosen top fraction of the catalogue, the same logic underlying all concentration figures in this report. Listener, review and follower metrics are taken at the show level and never aggregated across duplicate records, which prevents multi-contributor shows from inflating totals. Ratings are averaged; recency uses the most recent episode date.

10 How sponsorship, guests and video are detected

A show is classified as monetised where sponsorship or paid-placement signals are detected, as guest-led where guest appearances are identified, and as video-enabled where an associated YouTube presence exists. These are presence indicators, not measures of consumption: absence of a signal may reflect undetected activity rather than its certain absence. The video figure in particular is a linked-in-feed measure and undercounts real video, since well-known shows publish full video without a channel linked in their feed, so true adoption among established shows is probably materially higher. Presence-based sponsor detection may likewise not capture dynamically-inserted or programmatic advertising, so a show showing no detected sponsor may still carry ads; the unsponsored or untapped-inventory pool of roughly 5,118 shows should therefore be read as an upper bound. Detection itself is performed by MillionPodcasts' proprietary classifier and is not disclosed in detail here.

11 What the scorecard is

The self-assessment scorecard assigns weights to strategic traits according to how strongly each is associated with larger audiences in this dataset. It is a directional educational tool, not a predictive model: it describes correlations observed across the UK catalogue and should not be read as a forecast of any individual show's performance.

12 What "UK reviews" means

Throughout this report, "UK reviews" or "review count" refers to the public Apple Podcasts ratings count, the figure Apple displays on each show page as "X Ratings". This count is dominated by quick one-tap star ratings, with a smaller fraction of written reviews attached. It is the same metric Apple itself publishes, and it is what makes figures like 45,000+ for the top show realistic: most of those are star-only ratings, not full written reviews. We use it because it is the only consistent, publicly observable engagement signal across the entire UK catalogue.

13 What are the known limitations

Regional and city figures reflect the home city of the host or co-host as recorded in the source data, not the production or recording location of the podcast itself, and because it is inferred from the source data it can reflect a registered, agency or business address rather than a residence, which further concentrates apparent activity in London. Coverage is partial: only shows that resolve to a UK nation are included (2,739 shows, of which 2,400 also resolve to a named city). City shares are expressed against the full 2,739 base, so the 339 nation-only shows sit in the unlabelled remainder rather than being dropped from the denominator. The city analysis is filtered to UK locations only, excluding the small number of non-UK entries (for example, US states) that appear in the raw geography field. City counts should be read as a directional view of where UK podcasting talent clusters, not as a census of the full catalogue. Platform availability indicates distribution, not audience size on that platform. As with all observational data, correlations described here, for example between sponsorship, video and audience size, indicate association rather than proven causation.

14 How should the findings be cited

This research may be cited as: MillionPodcasts Research, The UK Podcast Landscape 2026. Snapshot date: August 2026. When referencing specific figures, we recommend linking to millionpodcasts.com/research/the-uk-podcast-landscape-2026 so readers can review the full methodology and context.

CITE THIS REPORT

"In 2026, the top 1% of UK podcasts captured about a fifth of all monthly listening; the top 10% captured around six in ten, across a catalogue of 6,693 established UK podcasts."

Source: MillionPodcasts Research, The UK Podcast Landscape 2026. Snapshot: August 2026.